

My Hero Is You Too





Ario's little problem

Ario the dragon sat alone on a cloud high up in the sky, higher than even the Hkakabo Razi. She saw the mountain ranges hugging the land like a ga-nge ... saw the strong, winding river cutting south across the central plains into the ocean ... and saw the long, pointy coast even beyond that. But today, this cloud did not make Ario feel better.

Children all over the world were growing more worried, angry, sad and hopeless each day. Ario couldn't really see those things, or hear them, but she felt them inside her large orange body and wanted to help.

Facilitator's note

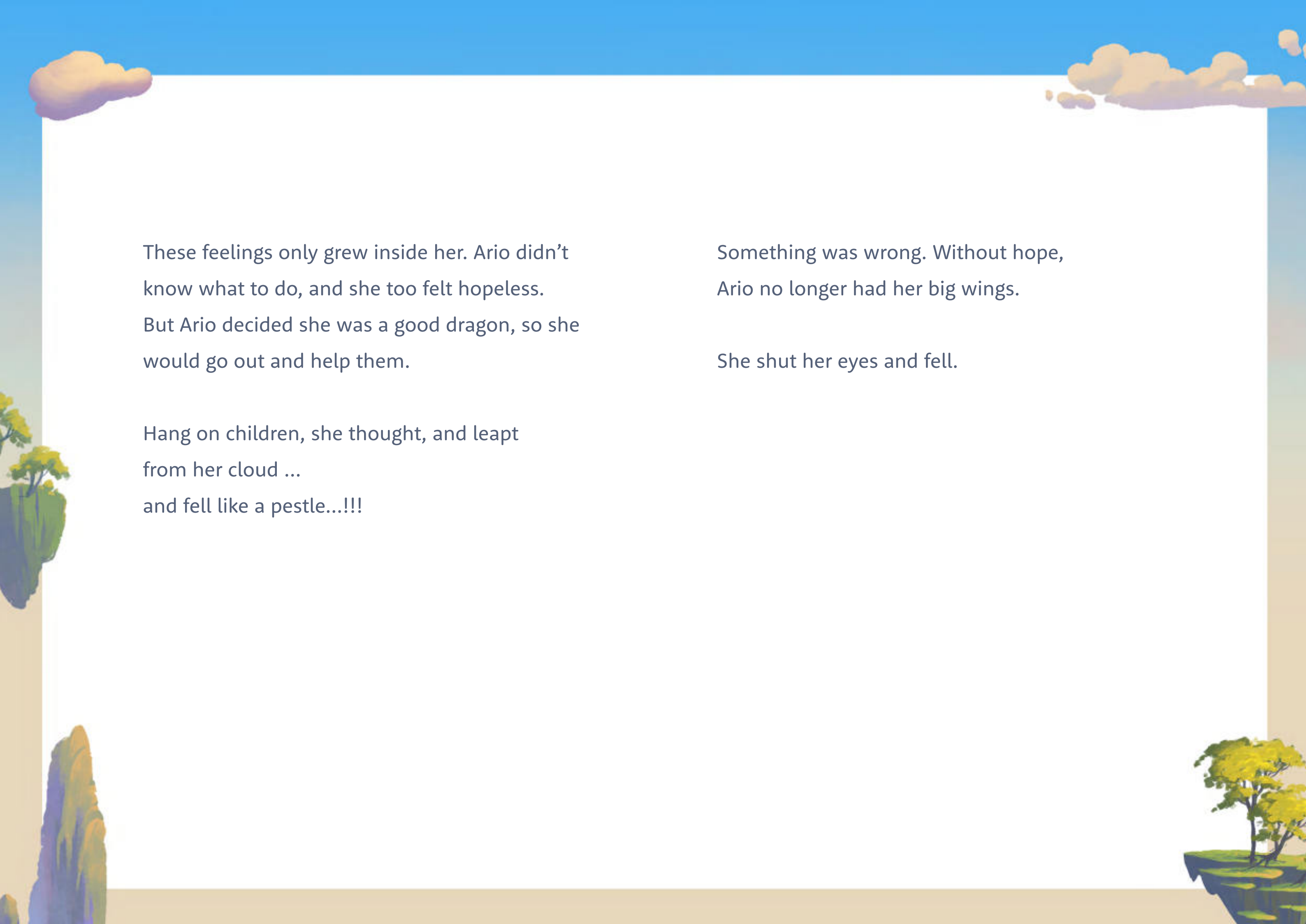
Why do you think some children might feel more worried now?



Chapter 1. Ario's little problem

Why do you think some children might feel more worried now?





These feelings only grew inside her. Ario didn't know what to do, and she too felt hopeless. But Ario decided she was a good dragon, so she would go out and help them.

Hang on children, she thought, and leapt from her cloud ...
and fell like a pestle...!!!

Something was wrong. Without hope, Ario no longer had her big wings.

She shut her eyes and fell.





The giant tree

Luckily., Ario the dragon landed in a giant tamarind tree. The tree looked ancient. It had more branches than Ario could count.

In the centre of its house-sized trunk sat a very large, wrinkly, and kind face, which asked:

“Are you ok, little dragon?”

Ario didn’t know where to begin.

“The children need help ... wings gone ... hopeless.”



Chapter 2. The giant tree





The fright from the fall, the heavy feelings in her stomach, being lost, and someone caring to ask emotions came to the dragon all at once, and spilled out in tears.

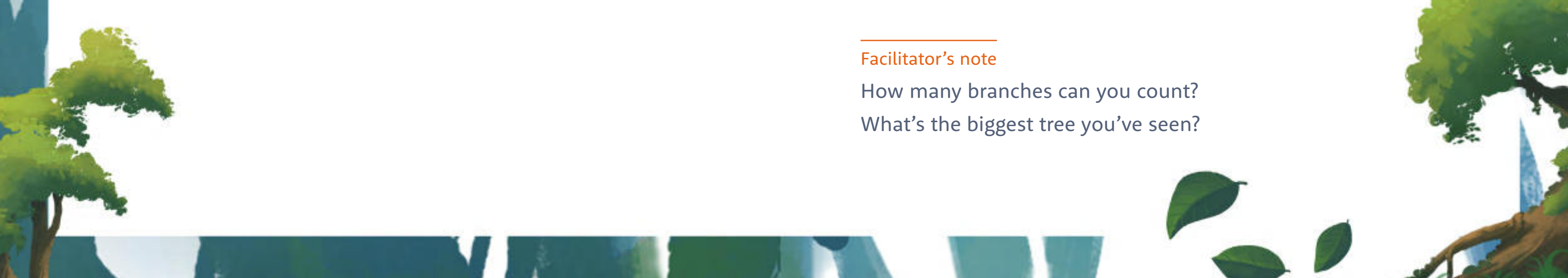
The old tree let Ario cry ... When Ario's tears slowed down, the tree spoke.

“It’s ok to be sad, everyone feels sad sometimes, even a tree as old as I. Don’t lose hope, little dragon.

I am Grandmother Sleep and Sour. Listen to my story.”

Facilitator’s note

How many branches can you count?
What’s the biggest tree you’ve seen?





How many branches
can you count? What's
the biggest tree
you've seen?





Grandmother Sleep and Sour's story

“I was a young sapling, as short as the little girl called May I once knew. My family of trees extended far and wide, and we shared this valley with a village, where May was from. May was so clever and so curious, and came to see me often.

The trees and humans lived together in harmony.”

“We protected their village from the storms that came every year, and the humans would only take from the forest what was necessary.

But humans got greedier over time, and cut down more and more of my tree community.”



Chapter 3. Grandmother Sleep and Sour's story





“The tree community shrunk slowly, until one year, a great storm arrived ... the biggest any human could remember ... loud and terrifying, it raged for days.

In the end, I was the only tree left in the entire valley. My family gone, the village gone, and the little girl ... May never returned to see me. Like you, I was sad and lost all hope that day.”
The tree was silent for a long time before continuing.

But I did find hope again! In this tiny seed pod that I found right here in this valley, in my home.

To me the seed pod meant there was still hope for more of my family, to start a tree community again.

My hope was only a tiny seed pod, but it was enough to sprout and grow. Slowly but surely (and it felt really slow at times even for a tree) my hope continued to grow as the tree community recovered. From the smallest of seed pods ...
... to this!”





The tree creaked and spread its branches.

“Find your hope as I found mine.”

The tree handed something to Ario. A seed pod.

Ario received it politely with both hands.

**“Find your hope and you will fly again,
little dragon.”**

The dragon knew it had to find hope to fly, but how? Unluckily for Ario, the tree had chosen that exact moment to take a nap.

Grandmother Sleep and Sour said she had found her hope again, so where could Ario find her hope again?

Ario decided to let the ancient tree sleep, and set off on foot in search of her hope.

At sundown, Ario came across a family of birds.

Facilitator's note

What are ways to help, support, or comfort others?

How do you help others?



What are ways
to help, support, or
comfort others? How
do you help others?

Ku Ku and family

The birds had large bags they carried on their backs ... even the little ones. They were migrating south.

The birds landed on a tree nearby. Ario saw how easily they flew, and wished she could join them. The dragon let out a big sigh. The youngest, Baby Ku Ku took notice of this and flew over.

“Are you a dragon? Are you lost? Do you need help? What happened to your wings?” Baby Ku Ku chirped rapidly.

“Slow down Baby Ku Ku, listening is just as important as asking,” Sister bird said.

Ario was grateful.

Chapter 4. Ku Ku and family



“I have lost my wings because I am feeling hopeless. But I want to fly to the children who need my help ... they must be feeling sad and worried. Do you know how I might feel hopeful again?” Ario replied.

“I don’t know, but we can ask Father” and the two birds quickly flew back to their family.

Father bird listened to Baby Ku Ku and called a family huddle. After some discussion, Father bird announced to Ario:

“Our family makes our big decisions together, so that we don’t leave anyone out. All of us want to help you. This forest is no place for a little dragon that cannot fly though. There is a small town nearby that we can take you, if you will allow us, my family can carry you.”



Ario felt humbled by the birds' kindness,
and appreciated that Father bird asked for
permission to carry her. Ario recognised she
needed help, so nodded.

The bird family lined up along her back, gently
holding the poor dragon. They counted to three,
and flapped their little wings in unison.

Ario was awed. The birds worked together and
timed their wings perfectly.

She floated and they were off!

Facilitator's note

How do you listen when others are speaking?
Tell me about one time you listened to a friend.



How do you listen when others are speaking? Tell me about one time you listened to a friend.

Ario's question

Ario had time to think in the air. She didn't feel like she was close to finding her hope, and felt guilty that the bird family were now carrying her, as well as their own heavy bags.

But she also felt comforted by the birds' help. She felt safer now, so felt talkative.

She asked Father bird. "Grandmother Sleep and Sour told me that I would be able to fly again if I found my hope. She got her hope back again when she found her seed pod — it was hope for a new forest of family and friends. It took so long but she has her forest and her hope now!"

"The children of the world are like my family. Because I sense inside of me that they are losing hope ... I feel hopeless too... which means I don't have my wings anymore ... and so I can't fly to the children and help them ... and this makes me feel more hopeless ... and it's all going in circles and ... and ... and ..."

"And ... I don't have time for Grandmother's seed pod to grow, and I don't know how to find hope quicker!"

Father bird nodded kindly to show he was listening, thought for a brief moment, then shared his story.

Facilitator's note

How many birds does it take to lift Ario?

Chapter 5. Ario's question



How many birds
does it take to
lift Ario?

Father Bird's story

“Do you know why birds move homes every year, Ario? Birds migrate every year because our feathers are light and we cannot survive when the cold comes. Every year we fly south for food and water.”

“Our journey takes days, even weeks, before we find somewhere to settle. Every year because of big changes that happen in the world, we have to move and rebuild our home from scratch. In all the uprooting, wouldn't it be easy to lose our hope?” Ario nodded.

“But for birds, our home isn't just a place. Our home is around us: our family, our flock. That's why we never lose hope. Our hope surrounds us.

Our journey is more tiring than most, so we know the best ways to keep spirits up. Different birds need different things, so we sing, play, or share stories to help us stay positive. Most importantly, we help each other. Our hope that we will always be together as a family and have each other, no matter where we live, this helps us fly.

Does this help you?”

Chapter 6. Father Bird's story



Ario is alone again

The group landed outside of the town. Ario tried to repay Ku Ku and their family, offering snacks she brought, but Father bird shook his head and said:

“One last thing about hope. It has to be shared.

Sometimes (even within our family!) some of us will stop believing that things can get better, so we all come together and help them hope again. We helped someone in need today. Tomorrow there might be others who will need a hand. We hope you will help them too.”

And with a lot of flapping, Ku Ku and their family continued their journey.

Ario the dragon was again alone, but for the first time today, she didn't feel so lonely. Ario was beginning to understand a little more. Hope could mean and come from different things. It could grow, it could be found at home, it could be family, and it could be shared. It could even come from just doing things like dancing and singing.

Ario walked along the small path leading to the town, and came across a cat sitting on a rock.

Facilitator's note

Have you helped anyone before?
What did you do?

Chapter 7. Ario is alone again



Have you helped
anyone before?
What did you do?



Ario and the cat

The cat was small, had spiky hair that stood up in all directions, and was the colour of midnight. It was watching the sky and nibbling stale pumpkin seeds, but when it saw Ario it hissed grumpily.

“Go away, there’s not enough food for the two of us.” Ario knew how hunger sometimes made her moody too. She took out her favourite peanut brittle snack and broke off a piece to share. The little cat was suspicious. But hungrily took the brittle and turned away to eat.

Ario felt good sharing. She asked the cat.

“May I sit down?” The cat turned around and gave Ario a strange look.

“This is the first time someone asked me for permission. People don’t think about how I feel because I’m little.” The cat stared at Ario for a bit, then agreed to let her sit down.

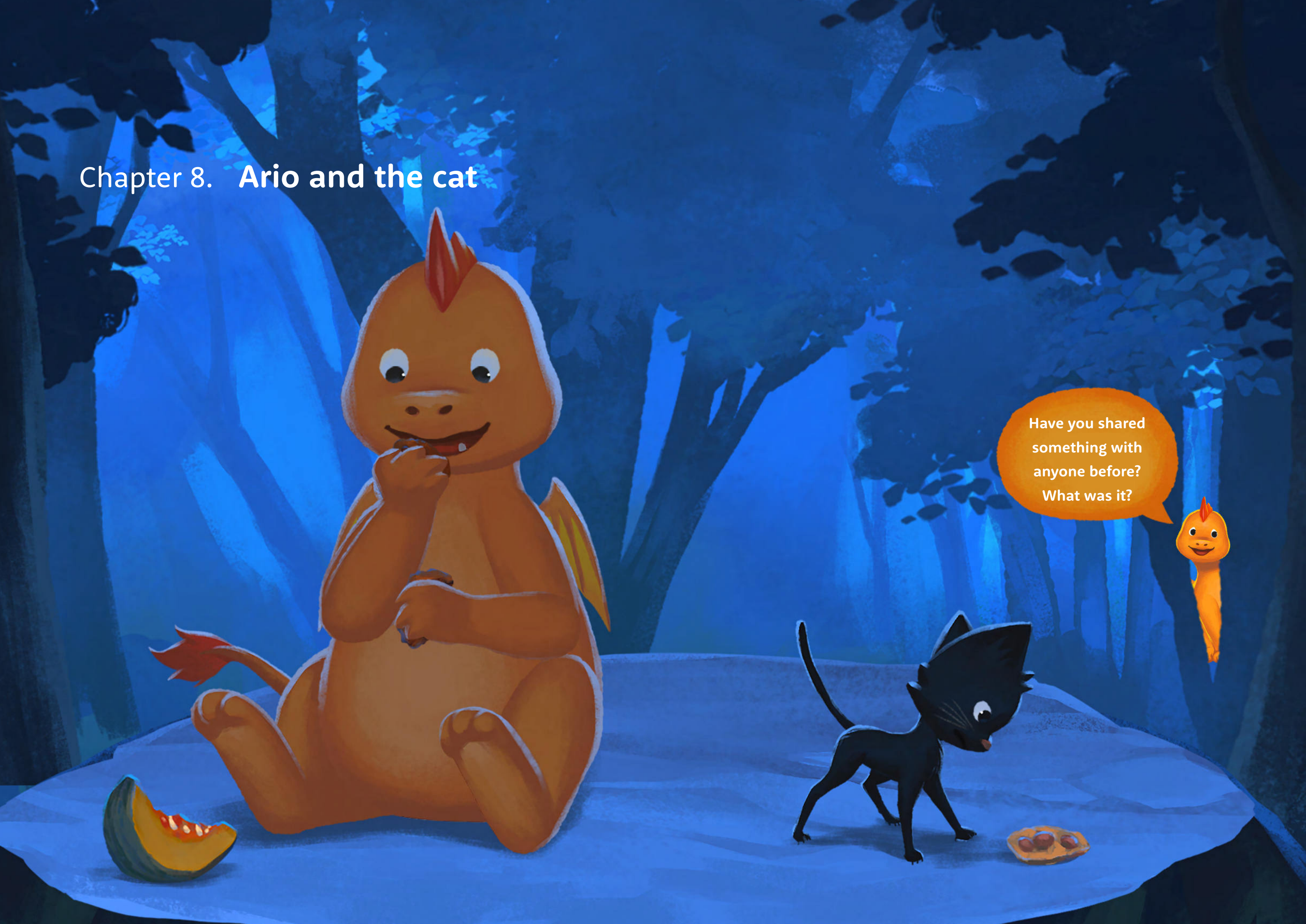
Ario and the cat sat, munching on peanut brittle.

They didn’t talk for a while. Ario had learnt from Grandma Sleep and Sour that it was ok to sit together in silence, and to listen. Ario and the cat spent that time getting the peanut brittle unstuck from their teeth. After getting one last tricky peanut piece from her teeth, the cat told Ario his story.

Facilitator’s note

Have you shared something with anyone before? What was it?

Chapter 8. Ario and the cat



Have you shared
something with
anyone before?
What was it?

Cat's story

“People in the town sometimes call me Crocodile, because I’m always snappy. But I don’t like that name.

I had a nice home a long time ago, but an angry fire took hold of it, and we had to run away. My family got separated and I ended up here. Most people in town don’t like black cats.

They think I bring bad luck and don’t give me food. The other cats don’t want to be my friends either, because they can’t count on me for food. They think I’m useless.”

“Perhaps I am useless. I’m always hungry and alone. But my favourite time is when the moon is out at night. I look at it, and feel full of hope. The moon can count on me to look at it, and when the night is all around: it feels like a hug. The moon and the night is my safe space. When I’m here, under the moon, I feel hopeful that there is a world out there where I’m accepted. That there are others out there who are kind, and that tomorrow will be better.”

Facilitator's note

Where or when do you feel safest?

Chapter 9. Cat's story

Where or when do
you feel safest?



New friends

Ario felt sad again, but not for herself. She wanted to help Cat.

“I’ll be your friend, Cat. I’ve had a horrible day too. I lost my wings and fell from the sky. An old tree said finding my hope would grow them back — will you help me?”

Cat cheered up at Ario’s words. “No one ever asks me for help. Of course I’ll help! Are you sure though?” “Don’t doubt yourself Cat. I believe in you,” Ario replied earnestly.

Cat was excited: “I don’t know about your hope, but I know where we might find a wishing pool! It’s a difficult journey, and I’ve not been too scared to go there alone, but if we go together, maybe we can wish for your wings there! Come!”

They first arrived at a stream. Cat was worried he couldn’t swim across, but Ario carried Cat on her back.

Next there were tricky rocks to climb. Since Cat had nimble feet, he instructed Ario which rocks to step on.

Chapter 10. New friends



At last they arrived at the wishing pool.
The water was perfectly still, the moon's
reflection clear in it.

"The moon is huge tonight!" Cat exclaimed.

"What will you wish for, my friend?" asked
Ario.

Cat replied, "I always hoped for a friend, and
now I have one, I don't need anything else.

I'll use my wish on your wings! You'll need
two wishes for both wings I think!"

Cat's words filled Ario's heart. And even
though it had been a long day, the dragon
did not feel tired one bit.

Facilitator's note

If you were at the wishing pool,
what would you wish for?



If you were
at the wishing
pool, what would
you wish for?



The wishing pool

Cat and Ario sat cross-legged, and held hands in front of the pool. They didn't wish out loud. With eyes closed, they wished deeply with their hearts.

They opened their eyes and the moon suddenly shined brighter ... but nothing happened!

"I'm so sorry Ario. I wished hard, I swear! I knew you couldn't count on me! I shouldn't have come."

But Ario was not upset at all.

"No Cat, it isn't your fault. It didn't need to work. Because of you, the KuKu and their family and Grandmother Sleep and Sour, I finally understand what hope is." Cat calmed down, and purred a bit.

"Hope isn't about getting what you want: it's about trying, EVEN if you fail sometimes! Hope is about a positive way of thinking. That you always believe that something good will happen, even in the hardest of times."

Ario and Cat hugged. The big dragon put the little cat's hands against her heart.

Facilitator's note

Have you tried but not succeeded before? Did you try again?

Chapter 11. The wishing pool

Have you tried but not
succeeded before? Did
you try again?



Ario's hopes

“Do you feel it? The world is breathing with hope. Everyone is hoping together ... the trees, the birds, the children all over the world. We just need to listen.”

“‘Mingalaba,’ people say to each other when they meet. They are hoping for good fortune to come for each other, a small way to be kind. Some share their snacks with loved ones and even strangers. Others share stories and confide in each other. Like all the friends I met today.”

“Some share their toys, others share jokes, but do you know what they are all trying to say?

Even without words, they are saying: ‘Be kind to one another, because together we hope that things will always get better!’”

“We just need to open our ears and our hearts. The whole world is hoping for a better place!” Cat felt it now. It was a glow in Ario’s heart. It grew brighter and brighter.

The hum grew so loud, it moved through Ario’s body now. Something was happening to Ario! In the moonlight, Ario’s wings finally grew from the hope in her heart. The two friends were stunned!

Chapter 12. Ario's hopes



Ario put Cat on her back and took off into the sky. They were flying! Cat had never been so close to the moon.

Ario finally understood Grandma Sleep and Sour's seed pod — it was hope for a better future! The dragon decided that the world needed to feel hopeful again.

Cat and Ario set off into the night to share hope with all the children of the world struggling to find their hope.

They decided they would plant Grandma Sleep's seed wherever it was needed, take time to listen to people and share their stories to whomever needed to hear.

And they hope that everyone, including you, feel they can do this too.

Facilitator's note

What do you hope for? Say, write, or draw your own hopes!



What do you hope for?
Say, write, or draw your
own hopes!

